NORTH-EAST

ASSAM

★ HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
From: Congress to BJP in 2015
USP: Chief architect of the BJP's expansion in the Northeast. A leader of the masses, he has mastered the art of backroom management



★ SARBANANDA SONOWAL
From: AGP to BJP in 2011
USP: Ex-AASU leader is a symbol of Assamese regionalism. Clean image helped the BJP gain ground initially, particularly in Upper Assam

TRIPURA

★ MANIK SAHA
From: Congress to BJP in 2016
USP: The dental surgeon is known for his organisational skills. Was made president of the state unit within four years of joining the BJP



MANIPUR

★ N. BIREN SINGH
From: Congress to BJP in 2016
USP: A trusted lieutenant of former Congress CM Okram Ibobi Singh, his departure opened the floodgates. Over two-thirds of the top Congress leadership followed him

ARUNACHAL PRADESH

★ PEMA KHANDU
From: Congress to BJP in 2016
USP: Almost the entire state Congress leadership joined the BJP along with Khandu. Son of ex-CM Dorjee Khandu, he has been central to BJP's expansion in Arunchal



★ KIREN RIJIJU
From: Congress to BJP in 2012
USP: Left BJP and joined Congress in 2009. Son of an ex-Congressman, Rijiju is now the most prominent tribal leader from the N-E

SIKKIM

DORJEE TSHERING LEPCHA
From: SDF to BJP in 2019
USP: Lepcha and 9 other MLAs from Sikkim Democratic Front (SDF) jumped ship, overnight making the BJP the largest Opposition party

★ Chief Minister ★ Union minister

EACH NEW ENTRANT HERALDS **A GEOGRAPHICAL EXPANSION INTO NEWER TERRITORIES...** IT'S A WHOLE PIECE OF THE INDIAN POLITICAL SOIL THAT GOES OVER TO THE BJP

Opposition parties ascribe a Machiavellian edge to what they call Operation Lotus. They allege that the BJP relies less on ideological persuasion and more on its seemingly inexhaustible resources—plainly visible in the resort politics it indulges in these days with as much aplomb as any non-ideological party, and all those chartered flights—and on midnight knocks by sleuths from central investigation agencies like the CBI and Enforcement Directorate. The BJP, on its part, does not seem to shy away from deploying the classical quartet of Chanakyan techniques—*saam, daam, dand, bhed* (persuasion, reward, punishment, division)—to effect splits and defections but rightly says it can't be blamed if other parties cannot keep their flock together. As a senior BJP leader says, referring to the defectors, "The horse must want to drink water before it comes to us, we cannot force it to do so." There may be resentment among old-timers in the party at the newbies taking the spoils of office, but he says, "We counsel them saying that if the BJP has to grow, we must all have a big heart. It is for a larger cause, we are not holding on to chairs for individuals." Power is its own logic and its own adhesive, of course, and confers on the BJP a natural advantage. But the plan it is playing to entails keeping a keen eye on India's political chessboard and moving into both the large gaps and the small crevasses.

One of the tactics it employs can be called the Earthmover—when a whole tectonic plate detaches itself from the geological shelf it was yoked to and links up with the saffron continent. If not exactly the whole legislature party, a significant enough chunk breaks off for the BJP to be able to make a conquest. That's what happened in Arunachal in January 2017 when Khandu joined the BJP with 33 MLAs in a 60-member House. And in Sikkim in August 2019, where the exodus of 10 out of his 15 MLAs eventually reduced the SDF of Pawan Chamling, the longest-serving CM of India, to a legislature party boasting a strength of one (himself). Variations of this theme played out in Karnataka, Goa, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra....

But it often needs at least a small crack to start with. Look no further than the Scindia episode. Jyotiraditya was unhappy with the Gandhi siblings for